



"This move means a lot to Kashmiris as they won't have just one land route for trading."

MUBEEN SHAH,
PRESIDENT, KCCI

spanning the border near Uri to slogans of "*aar paar tijarat zindabad*" (long live the cross-border trade). The response on the PoK side was equally heart-warming when an equal number of mini-trucks laden with Kashmiri apples, walnuts, almonds and spices drove across the 40-m bridge, named Aman Setu (bridge of peace). "I could never imagine the two Kashmiris exchanging commodities in my lifetime," said 65-year-old local resident Aziz Naik who has only seen war and conflict in his time. He was among the curious but enthusiastic villagers waving at the Pakistani goods convoy as it drove along the meandering Jhelum River to unload its consignment at a trade facilitation centre in Salamabad, 13 km from the LOC.

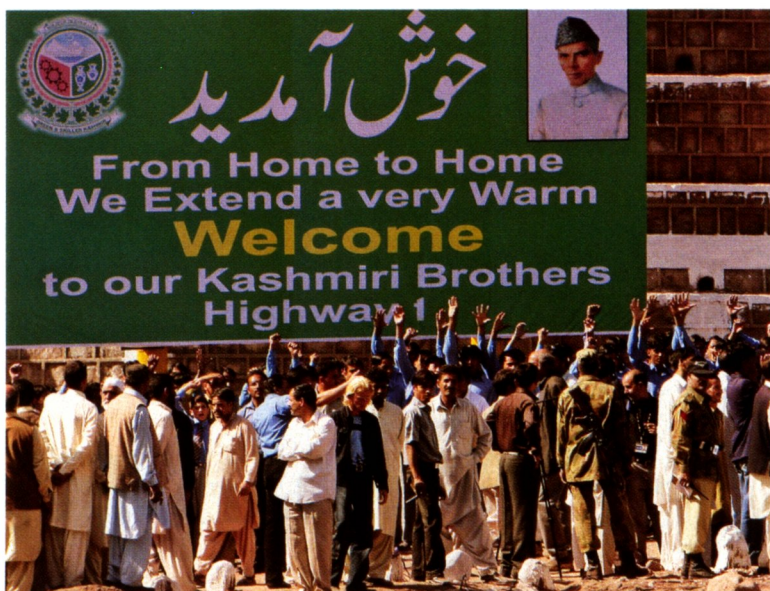
The move has struck a positive chord in the sullen Valley. The emotional and economic spin-off of intra-Kashmir trade is not lost on the

peculiarly between the two parts of Jammu and Kashmir which are claimed by both India and Pakistan, the trans-LOC trade would be with respect to 21 commodities short-listed by the commerce ministries. Only commodities produced or manufactured locally figure in the trading list which will be subject to a review every three months. To begin with, trucks with 1.5-tonne capacity will ply across the LOC two days a week on travel permits.

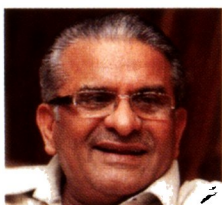
The trading communities on both sides of the LOC are bullish about the opening of new markets. "There is a sea of trade potential waiting to be exploited between the divided Kashmiris," says Zulfikar Abbasi, president of the Muzaffarabad-based Azad Jammu and Kashmir Chamber of Commerce and Industry who recently led a business delegation from PoK to Jammu and Srinagar. "The LOC trade not only offers an opportunity for Kashmir fruit and handicraft exports to grow by at least 20 per cent, but it will cultivate a better business enterprise to tap the international dollar markets through Pakistan," says Abdul Hamid Punjabi, secretary general of the KCCI.

"We want the trans-LOC trade to be not merely symbolic but substantive," says Ram Sahai Kakkar, president of Jammu Chamber of Commerce and Industry (JCCI) which has already proposed another 19 locally-manufactured goods for expanding the list of items. The Chambers based in Muzaffarabad, Srinagar and Jammu have forged a common platform in the form of the "Federation of Jammu and Kashmir Chamber of Commerce and Industry" and made a slew of recommendations to their respective governments to remove the roadblocks on logistics to make the trade substantive and sustainable. Their main concerns involve strengthening road and bridge infrastructure to facilitate trucks with 10- to 15-tonne load, upgradation of telecommunication and courier services between the two Kashmiris, and allowing banking transactions across the LOC.

Also, traders are seeking cross-LOC travel on multiple-entry permits valid for at least six months in place of single-visit permit allowed only to the divided Kashmiri families of both sides. While the authorities in India and Pakistan hope to address these issues as the trade gathers pace, an immediate impediment is the ticklish issue of the trading currency, with traders from both sides suggesting dual currency with reference to the US dollar or Euro. But, as India and Pakistan agree to trade trust, and Jammu and Kashmir gets into poll mode, the cross-LOC trade could well be a new currency of peace between them. ■



A NEW WAVE: PoK traders wave at their Indian counterparts near Aman Setu



"We want the trans-LoC trade to be not merely symbolic but substantive."

RAM SAHAI KAKKAR,
PRESIDENT, JCCI

ordinary Kashmiri considering that the opening of the Jhelum valley road has been a long-standing demand, articulated even by Sheikh Abdullah. "Uniting the two Kashmiris for trade means a lot to the Kashmiris. It has removed their long-entrenched psychological barrier that they have only one land route for trading," says Mubeen Shah, president of the Kashmir Chamber of Commerce and Industry (KCCI). Even the separatists have grudgingly hailed the move, with Mirwaiz Umer Farooq, chairman of the moderate Hurriyat faction, calling it "a positive step towards the final political resolution of the Kashmir dispute".

Billed as a zero-tariff trade because it is